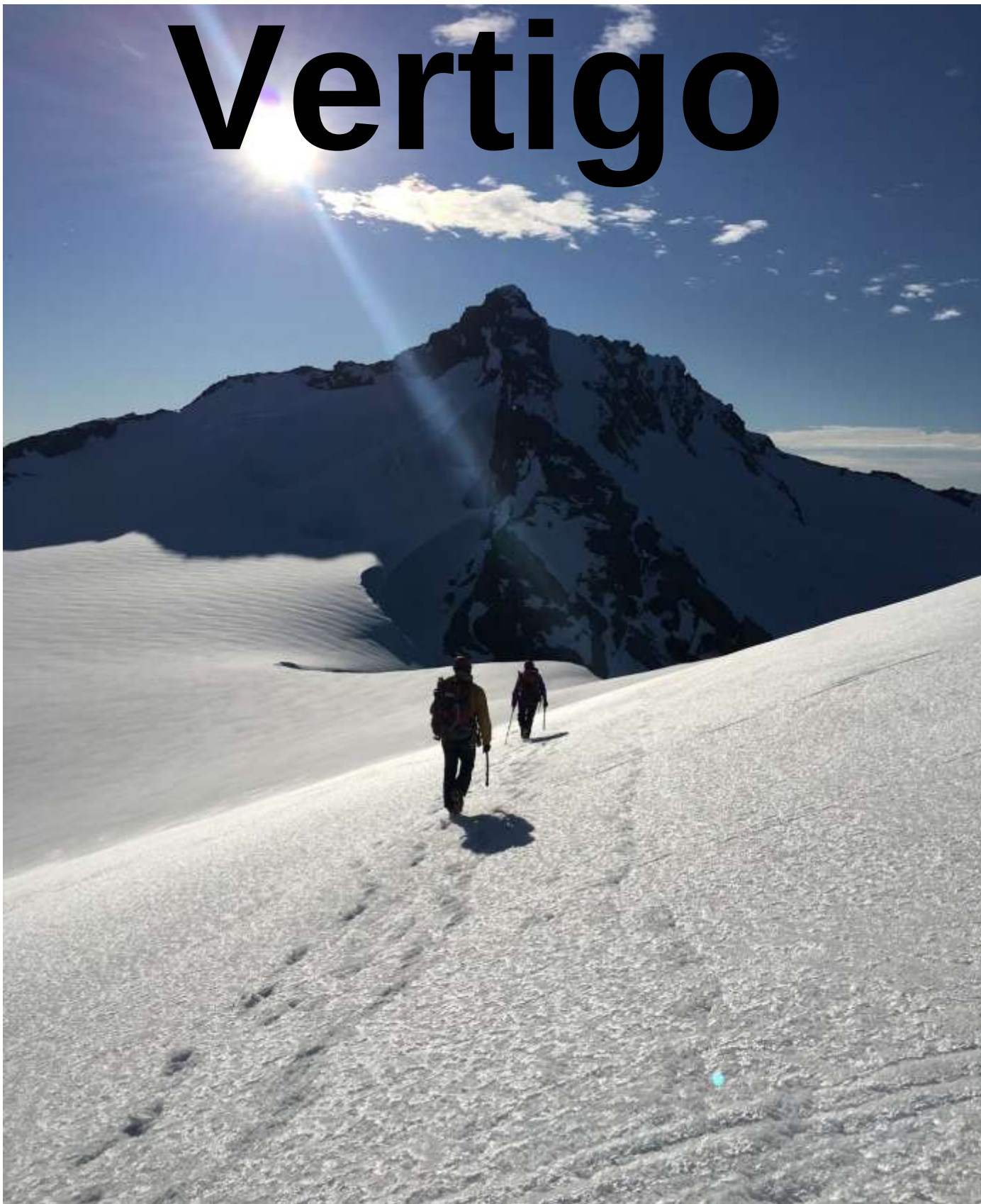


Vertigo



(Photo by Mark Henson: Nina Sawicki and Rob Hawes en route to Mt. Avalanche 2606 m: West Ridge directly in front)

Section News

Section Nights

We received positive feedback from those who attended our April section night where we had Leigh Matheson from the Met Service present on weather followed by Ric Cullinane from Walking Access presenting to us on the role of Walking Access and information about their mapping service.

We are excited to have Daniel Joll as our guest speaker at the May Section Night.

Daniel will be sharing some stories of various ascents in the European Alps, mainly around Chamonix. He has made seven trips to the Alps (three winter and four summer), with around 60 successful ascents including classics like the north faces of the Eiger, the Grandes Jorasses and the Dru.



Grandes Jorasses

Come along, invite your friends and grab a drink from the bar – there'll be time for a catch up and chat after the meeting.

Chair's Report

As a climate change sceptic, I'm sceptical that the scientists are really telling us what they think. Each year their forecasts predict that global warming will be worse and faster than they predicted the previous year. Add to this their reputation for being conservative then multiply by a factor of 8.5 and you either have more snow than you can shake an ice axe at or more rock than a month of climbing Sundays. Of course there is climate change and as humans we live in denial for as long as we can get away with it. In the mean time we have had some of the best weather this side of the last ice age and with it yet another forecast for a warmer than average winter (Metservice). This doesn't bode well for anyone, especially those of us enamoured with the cold white fluffy stuff. On the other hand there are four fingers and a thumb (Tommy Cooper) and, if warm wet airflow from the north meets cold dry airflow from the south, we could have masses of the stuff so best sign up for a winter snow craft course while there are still spaces. On the up side, while we are going down with the ship, if the freezing level drops and the clear days and especially nights of late continue we should have some boomer ice to nail by Queen's Birthday weekend.

Last month's section night was a bit of an experiment in that we diverted from the traditional worship of the uber-climber and provided a more instructional evening focused on weather and mapping. From all accounts this was not only interesting and informative but also entertaining. Who said severe weather forecasters don't have a sense of humour. Inspired by this success we called on our team of researchers to consult the oracle and run some focus groups. They came up with nutrition, hygiene and sanitation (faecal transplants - kind of related) and mountain yoga (aka fitness for fun). So we have an APB out for entertaining speakers on these topics. So far we have one on faecal transplants or transpoosions as they are known in the trade. So if you know anyone who can hold their own on nutrition or fitness, please get in touch. Don't panic yet though as we have an all time favourite, Dan Joll back to regale us on his latest alpine survival experience and what the NZ Alpine Team has been 'up' to.

See you next Wednesday at the Southern Cross.

Simon

For quick access to the section’s page on the NZAC website, scan the below QR code.



Upcoming Trips, Courses and Events

Wellington Section Trips

The following are trips that are being planned by the committee. The section continues to subsidise rental vehicles for the South Island trips to make the trips more affordable. Keep an eye on our Facebook page for more details or email us on wellington@alpineclub.org.nz to let us know if you're keen to come along. Also, please contact us if you're keen to run a trip yourself – the committee can help with advertising / logistics.

When?	Where?
Queen's Birthday Weekend	Seaward Kaikouras
August 25-28	Remarkables Ice and Mixed Festival

Wellington Section Snowcraft courses

Beginner course:

- moving on snow using ice axe and crampons
- evaluating terrain for safe travel
- navigation
- avalanche transceiver use

This course focuses on taking participants new to mountaineering into the mountains to gain skills, confidence and experience in the alpine environment. It requires good fitness and caters to those with little or no experience on snow or ice. It involves learning the basics of moving around in alpine terrain safely, using an ice axe and crampons, identifying terrain hazards and basic emergency procedures. It does not include ropes. It assumes prior knowledge of tramping and self management in a remote environment. It does not assume prior knowledge of alpine skills.

Intermediate course:

- using ropes & snow anchors

This course builds on the competencies of a beginner, adding rope, anchors and belays and single pitch climbing. The course assumes prior knowledge of core snow craft skills such as cramponing, transceiver searches, ice axe use and self management in a remote alpine environment.

Advanced course:

- pitching and travel

This course focuses on consolidation of the skills covered in the beginner and intermediate courses and applying them to pitched climbing and travel in an alpine environment.

Course Dates

22-24 July (pre-course evening 14 July); split Beginner and Intermediate course

12-24 August (pre-course evening 4 August) split Beginner and Intermediate course.

26-28 August (pre-course evening 18 August) Advanced course.

All pre-course evenings are in Wellington at Bivouac on the Thursday night a week prior at 6pm.

Courses are held at the Tukino lodge on Mt Ruapehu and include accommodation for two nights, main meals and transport from the two wheel drive car park. The section provides selected equipment for hire (except boots, clothing and personal items) for \$5 an item per 7 days.

The course fee has increased slightly this year and has been set at \$270. You need to be a member of the NZAC to attend our snowcraft courses. See <http://alpineclub.org.nz/apply-for-membership/> for details on how to signup to the NZAC. There is a \$100 deposit payable on registration with final payment due 2 weeks before the course commences. Payments are refundable up to a week prior to the start date of the course after which the deposit is forfeited.

Registration forms will be available on Facebook and on our section page of the NZAC website very soon.

Trip Reports

A Spring Foray to the Upper Bonar Glacier November 2015

Rob Hawes Nina Sawicki and Mark Henson

It has taken some two months from completing this trip to having peace of mind to write of its beauty and challenges. The intervening weeks have been fractured with the death of two climbing companions. I have felt halted in a "no-man's land" where it has felt disrespectful to speak of alpine beauty knowing that it has just claimed the life of one mountaineering friend. Despite our communal and often unspoken awareness of the inevitability of risk we are nonetheless shocked and distressed by a friend's death. My other friend died by suicide. Ironically, the beauty and the inherent challenges of climbing had probably gifted us his presence for longer. The mountains take but they also give.

Rob, Mark and I had planned to climb Mt Avalanche last year having seen it on several occasions both from the summit of Aspiring and during that slog across the Bonar glacier. Mt Avalanche seems the poor relation of Aspiring and does not draw the masses, yet it stands proud, flanked by its rocky buttresses at the head of the Upper Bonar seemingly guarding the passageway to the glacier below. We walked in on a clearing forecast but holed up at Aspiring Hut to wait out a wet day: none of us were keen to arrive at French Ridge Hut dripping wet in preparation for the week ahead. We made great mates with Stu, the hut warden, and later enjoyed his company at French Ridge Hut. Stu is fit, knowledgeable, experienced and understated: if you can draw him out he will talk of the many rescues he has completed (often solo) to retrieve bodies from under the schrund at the bottom of the Ramp. Stu later supplied us with goodies from the food stores at French Ridge Hut. The slog up French Ridge does not get easier (four years since my last foray) but this time there were no tears of exhaustion, just a quiet calm that eventually it would stop and we would arrive. This time I was spared the crop of blisters on my shoulders from the pack straps. I could be wiser and travelling lighter or maybe my shoulder skin is simply thickening like my foot pads?

We arrived at French Ridge Hut on a magnificent but windy day and took our time to absorb the surrounding beauty sipping endless cups of tea on the balcony.



Happy Times: Endless cups of tea at French Ridge Hut

Two climbers joined us in the late afternoon. They had completed a "hut to hut" climb of the SW Ridge of Aspiring (they soloed the crux in what they described as perfect conditions). Later I read that these two young men had been invited to join the NZ Alpine Team and so were building up their climbing portfolio in anticipation. We set off for the West Ridge of Avalanche the next day at 5.00 am: clear with a light wind. On the ascent up to the Quarterdeck we encountered perfect cramponing conditions and only one or two small slots to negotiate. We had stunning views west across to Earnslaw and as we gained height we could clearly make out the form of both the East and West peaks of Earnslaw. We paused to reflect on the death of Simon Bell: a talented young Wellington climber and aspiring engineer who probably went missing on the West Peak of Earnslaw almost a year ago (but now a year at the time of writing this). I felt my breakfast reverse its direction as Simon occupied my thoughts. I did not know Simon well but my last memory of him was at Unwin Hut in November 2014 over a shared meal post Aoraki summit celebration for Rob and I. Simon spoke excitedly of the months of climbing ahead on his planned break from work. What a magnificent spot to rest and in many ways it was comforting to see its grandeur: fitting for the person Simon was.

I thought of the words of Geoffrey Winthrop Young (an early English Himalayan explorer).

*What if I live no more those Kingly days?
Their night sleeps with me still,
I dream my feet upon the starry ways,
My heart rests in the hill,
I may not grudge the little left undone
I hold the heights, I keep the dream I won*

Maybe I have a romantic streak or maybe I struggle with the possibility of a life devoid of meaning but I think not. Not only did climbing enrich Simon but also the lives of those around him. I thank him for his support on difficult "steps" on various peaks that I may not have taken but for his encouragement.



Nina climbing up to the Quarterdeck in the dawn light

The climb of the West Ridge of Mt. Avalanche continues up the glacier on the north side to avoid the gendarmes which guard the lower section of the ridge. We traversed across the top of the wind scoops and gained the ridge by traversing across to the west face and then delicately up to the bottom of the slabs. The first slab is straightforward but always a toss-up: crampons on or off? I elected to keep them on as I actually find climbing with crampons helpful and I can get my spikes in those tiny cracks. I had bought new aggressive crampons specifically for this and they worked really well. There was an airy traverse round to the first slabs which was straightforward but exposed and this led us to another patch of ice: thin but cold and firm just below the second set of slabs. It was good practice to juggle standing on an exposed small ice stance while removing our packs, removing crampons, attaching them to the pack and then putting out packs back on all while standing on the small ice step with not a great deal to hold onto!



Nina and Mark ascending the first slabs

The second slab was steeper and more exposed. Uttering my proverbial frustrating un-committing "umm..." as I approached it, Rob kindly (and discretely) threw down a rope but once on the slabs they were actually quite straightforward. Mark came up behind me without a rope. Above the second slabs the climbing was straightforward but sustained and steep with a thin layer of ice on rock. It was not consistently hard and I heard the worrying sound of water running underneath. A recent winter climb of Single Cone with Nick Allen (CEO of Mastering Mountains: a charitable trust for people with Multiple Sclerosis) presented similar conditions and prepared me well. By the time we summated, the wind had picked up and some clouds had started to scud by.



Nina and Rob on the summit of Mt. Avalanche: Mt French on the right with the Breakaway toward the centre

The descent was straightforward but we were careful not to move too closely together, being cautious about the stability of the ice. We abseiled off the higher slab and down climbed the lower one back down to the wind scoops.



Rob abseiling off the higher slab: here you can see our route clearly across the wind scoops onto the lower slabs (above the Francis Maude Glacier)

The next day we had a rest day (inclement weather and wind) and we were joined by several entertaining professional guides and clients over the next few days as they returned from successful Aspiring summits. One of the most notable clients was a young engineer who was recovering from a fractured cervical spine, and he spent several hours in the bunk room doing his regular work-out. ("My goodness" I thought "Is not climbing Aspiring sufficient ..?" apparently not!) Another guide from Italy had left behind three young children for the southern climbing season and was beholden to bring them back a picture of a sheep. However he was captivated by the antics of the Kea whom we thought would win the hearts of the children over the sheep. We enjoyed Stu's food stash of goodies that day with a delicious full cream chocolate mousse being the high-light followed by my home-made bliss balls.

After a day of rest we headed up again to the Quarterdeck leaving at 4.00 am to climb the Popes Nose 2700 m. The day was brilliantly clear but the wind chill ferocious. (*Can you guys remember? Temp and wind speed*). The climb to the Pope's Nose is 1400 m from French Ridge Hut and we again enjoyed perfect cramponing conditions. We encountered some large crevasses as we ascended higher to the ridge on the upper slopes of the glacier so we made a decision to get out the rope having felt confident un-rope on the lower Bonar.



Imposing South face of Aspiring (climbed by Simon and Rob winter of 2014) with the higher aspect of the Coxcomb ridge on the right

As we climbed higher the wind chill intensified. We started the airy traverse (some 1000 m above the Kitchener Cirque) to the summit proper but I noted Mark about 10 metres ahead who had starting to down climb. "It's too cold" he gasped. It was also extremely windy and both of us were struggling to stay upright: the prospect of a traverse above the Kitchener cirque was not appealing. My wide-bore water bottle with electrolyte solution froze within the last 20 minutes. Mark decided to put on another layer and get out of the wind. I quickly put on my down jacket and within minutes we both felt better but I had to smash the ice in my bottle with my axe to get fluids. We watched Rob "two tool" along the final aspect of the ridge to complete the last few metres to the rocky summit proper and then make a rapid descent back to us. We descended quickly to the lower Bonar and the prospect of sunshine but it still remained bitterly cold. Mark had been unable to eat much and was not feeling that well and so headed back to the hut. After lunch Rob and I picked a nice line up the face of Mt. French: an enjoyable solo climb sussing out the firmer snow as we weaved our way through the rock bands.



Nina on her way up the line on Mt. French

I worked my way to the firmer snow top right and through the rocks to the summit ridge. Topping out on Mt French gave us spectacular views down to the Matukituki Valley below and an impressive view of the shadows of Gloomy Gorge. When we reached the hut Mark had perked up and was feeling better. The next day was another good climbing day and Rob sent off to climb the SW face of Mt. Avalanche (now confident of the descent route). I had some impressive blisters (probably from different forces on my boots with new crampons) and Mark decided on a rest day to really recover from his bug. Rob returned in the early afternoon successful and jubilant. Rob had first seen the SW face of Mt Avalanche many years back from the kitchen window of French Ridge hut and had long had his eye on it. The weather was good, the snow was well consolidated, he had time and we had established a descent route down the NW ridge from our earlier climb.

Rob departed around 3.30am for the Bonar, across to the flight deck arriving there at 5.30am and so was able to make use of "useable daylight". He dropped down from the flight deck at 2300m to the Maud Francis glacier at 2000m. Rob moved across the Maud Francis and up to 2200m. He needed to pick his line and looking at a line from directly below is different from 2km away from the hut. Rob confirmed his ideal route with his GPS.

Just as Rob prepared to climb he glanced over his shoulder and the sun had just touched the tops of Sir William, Pluto and Mt Earnslaw, where our friend Simon had gone missing and Rob reflected for a while about Simon and decided to dedicate this solo climb to Simon.

The real climb started at 2300m and topped out just over 2600m and is a constant 60 degree slope. The first 100m vertical is on a snow slope with the next 200 on a lovely arête, 2 tools and front pointing all the way. With firm snow conditions it is a lovely climb, yes exposed, but given it is a direct line straight up, a very comfortable solo line. The climb topped out about 30m south of the summit and a little below it. It required a delicate traverse along a knife edge ridge which was the most challenging section of the climb. On one side of the traverse is the route just climbed, the other is the Hood glacier in the Kitchener Cirque - an unprotected fall either side was unacceptable. The traverse forced Rob from one side to the other and back several times and at times 1 tool and 1 foot on each side.



The route along the summit ridge after the ascent from the South West face

The reward was a pleasant, calm and clear summit. The descent was straightforward following the descent route from the earlier climb of the NW ridge. A solo climb of the SW face was a very pleasant and recommended 6 or 7 hour return day from French Ridge hut.

We descended that day to Aspiring Hut along with the chirpy companionship of another guide also called Mark and his very fit client. With the heat in the valley that afternoon, the guide was happy to "let him go" and he sped off to the hut. We had a lot of fun that night at Aspiring Hut with the guide Mark and shared a lot of banter about gear and how to minimise pack weight (all

my gear was strewn across the floor being scrutinised piece by piece). I'll be cautious about complaining about the weight of my pack in future!

Mark (guide) told me later the news of Stefan Spörli's suicide but one week earlier in November. I felt the news like the blast of an avalanche, and I went immediately to wake (friend) Mark up (who was dozing) to share my grief. I struggled to physically get the words out of my mouth. Later in December when I spoke at Stefan's memorial service at his parent's house in Auckland I recalled that "visceral punch" on first hearing this news. Stefan was an exceptionally talented climber, skier mountain guide and artist. When I think of Stefan and his love of the mountains these words come to me.

Petrarch (c 1345):

Up where no over shadowing mountain stands

Towards the great and the loftiest peak

A fiery longing draws me

Shortly after this trip Rob and Steve Dowall set off to climb the North Ridge of Cook via the Empress Ice shelf. Steve never made it to Empress Hut and is presumed dead (although his body has not been located). Steve's memorial service in Timaru in early December was a fitting tribute to a man of great integrity and commitment to the welfare of others. Like Stefan, it was evident that the mountains sustained Steve through his life, and something he had shared with his father Alf. Ironically today as I complete this, I read in the Taranaki Herald of the legacy of Steve Dowall and his work in Myanmar addressing poverty and malnutrition. I have referred to three great men who have been woven into this story. We saw the resting place of Simon on this climb; we heard the news of Stefan's death toward the end of our trip and I have delayed writing this to give space to both Steve and Stefan's memorial services and to allow Rob time to process his grief before reflecting on his personal solo climb of the SW face of Mt. Avalanche.

As a doctor my work frequently presents the injustices of untimely death and illness. Something I have found helpful for me comes from a psychotherapist Stephanie Dowrick:

Life is frequently unfair. At such times, we should love more fiercely. Not less.

(Stephanie Dowrick)

Earnslaw IV

Josh Pemberton

Those who prefer to conduct their Easter egg hunts out of doors would have done well to avoid the Mt Aspiring National Park in recent years. Late March and early April have tended to feature the sort of miserable weather that puts a dampener on oological pursuits – and, for those who'd rather seek out summits than eggs, on climbing too. Two members of our group of four had attempted Mt Earnslaw / Pikirakatahi three times on Easter weekends between 2010 and 2013, only to be forced down on each occasion by unfavourable conditions.

Because both Easter and eggs are symbolic of new beginnings – or, perhaps, simply because some itches need scratching – it was decided that a fourth attempt should be made over Easter 2016. Our group, including two Wellington section members, planned to assemble from around the country in Christchurch on the afternoon of the Thursday before Easter and drive to Wanaka that night. We'd have the whole of the long weekend set aside for Earnslaw IV, as it had been named.

There were the usual pre-trip hiccups. Most notably, flight delays prevented one of the party from arriving in Christchurch until 10.30pm on the Thursday evening, forcing us to drive through the night. We arrived in Wanaka at the very hour we'd intended to be getting up and leaving – 3.30am. Yet two hours in bed and a breakfast of Up&Go proved sufficient to revitalise us, and by sunrise we were on the road heading toward Glenorchy. If anyone wasn't already feeling the lift that comes with consuming a litre of Sanitarium's finest lifestyle milk product, the confirmation of a good forecast was enough to raise spirits all around.

Our four-wheel drive vehicle took us a short way past the Rees Valley road-end and from there we were on foot. After 90 minutes or so of walking up the Rees we farewelled the cattle and began the 1700 metre climb to Esquilant Bivvy, our intended accommodation for the night. The route follows the Kea Basin Track for the first few hundred vertical metres, before climbing out above the bushline. As we gained height we were rewarded with increasingly impressive views across the cloud-filled Rees. Tracks in the mud suggested we'd have company for the evening.

The tussock of Kea Basin increasingly gives way to rock and, eventually, to the Birley Glacier. We'd bought full kit and so, upon reaching the Glacier, decided to not only put on crampons but to rope up as well. In good



Crossing the Birley Glacier

time and without incident we reached Wright Col and then the Biv, where the first priority was to put on a much-needed pot of Mie Goreng noodles. Three or four other groups eventually arrived; far too many to squeeze into the Biv. Fortunately there were enough tents to go around – though regrettably, the same could not be said for the Mie Goreng. There was noticeably less snow around the Col and below the Glacier than on previous trips. The Biv itself contained tributes to Simon Bell, who went missing on Mt Earnslaw in January 2015.



View north-east across the Birley Glacier

The next day dawned bright and clear, revealing that the 600 or so vertical metres from the Biv to the Earnslaw's East Peak (2,830m) were entirely free of snow. The out-and-back nature of the route to the top meant that we were able to leave most of our kit at the Biv to collect en route down. The scramble to the top was fairly straightforward, though in places care was required, especially

with verglass and the odd tight squeeze.



Keyhole squeeze between Wright Col and the summit

If the views had been impressive on the first day, they were stunning from the summit. To the West lay the Pluto Peak and the Humboldt Range; to the East, the Richardson and Harris Mountains and, further North, Mt Aspiring / Tititea. Clouds pooled above Lake Wakatipu and in the Rees and Dart Valleys and above, we were in bright sunshine.



Summit!

When we finally brought ourselves to leave the summit, the descent back to the Col and down the hill were leisurely, although some bruised knees and toenails began to make themselves known.

The rock biv just above the bushline that we'd planned to sleep in was filled up, containing groups both heading up and on the way back down. We decided to therefore spend the night in Earnslaw Hut, a rustic beech and corrugated iron structure set in the bush. The hut features hessian sack bedding and a fireplace that we put to good use.



Earnslaw Hut



Sunset over Pluto Peak

The next morning the weather remained perfect until about half an hour after we'd got back to the car, when it started spitting. On the fourth attempt, we'd been treated to perfect conditions and had made it to the top and back without incident. It goes to show that – just like Easter Eggs – some climbs really are worth waiting for.



End of the trip – Rees Valley – l-r David, David, Hamish and Josh

Notices

New book in the section library – Occasional Climber by Peter Laurenson

The section has purchased a copy of Peter's book for the section library. Your Vertigo editor has been lucky enough to be the first one to get her hands on it. If you'd like to be the next borrower please let Carolyn know. The book is proving to be an interesting and inspiring read so far and the photos are stunning!

Lost Camera – Homer Hut

Nikon AW1 in case with BD Carabiner attached, lost at Homer Hut around 2nd-9th of February 2016. Has photos from climbing in Canada, Thailand, Laos and Australia. Last seen at the picnic tables. Please contact me at allanjt@hotmail.com if found, I would just like my photos from the Darrans.

End of fee collection boxes in NZAC huts

The last two hut fee collection boxes have been removed from Arthur's Pass and Porter Lodge. Bookings for huts should be made online here: [hut bookings](#).

When paid you will be sent a confirmation email with the latest hut code entry numbers where applicable. Unwin bookings will require confirmation by the Managers first. If you owe for past bookings, or wish to make a large group booking, please [contact](#) the office.

Wellington Section 2016 contacts list

We are always thankful for volunteers and members stepping forward to help the section run smoothly. If you'd like to learn more about how you could get involved, please email us at

wellington@alpineclub.org.nz

Position	Name	Contact
Chairperson	Simon Williamson	021 054 7684
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Treasurer	Mark Leslie	027 338 4458
Secretary & Vertigo editor	Carolyn Ellis	021 574 287
Patron	John Nankervis	
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	Mark Johnston	027 924 4178
	Sharron Came	
	Gina Butson	
	Elisha Watson	
Rock Drill Overseer	Jeremy Tries	027 55 55 893
Any membership, Distaghil Sar Fund, or general queries should be directed to the secretary		



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